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Title:
## It's an Emergency

Author:
## Lisa Ridarelli

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Publication Date: September 1, 2022

Published by
MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS
U.S.A.

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# IT'S AN EMERGENCY

**By: Lisa Ridarelli**

**Cast of Characters**

PALOMA

SERGIO

**Setting**

Paloma's apartment

*(PALOMA, in neat silk pajamas, lounges on couch. She drinks tea, talks on the phone.)*

PALOMA
Thanks for checkin' on me. *(Pause.)* Yea, it's been a few months. Nope. Have not seen him. I've got an oil diffuser misting, calm music. Pretty much a living room spa. *(Pause.)* You said, I'm resilient? Whew, I like that. Of course. Okay, muah, bye.

*(PALOMA hangs up, takes a moment, sighs, smiles to herself. She sips her tea, sits down to journal. DOORBELL. She looks through the peep hole.)*

PALOMA
*(To herself)* Oh no. Oh, no, no, no, no. *(Through the door)* I have nothing to say to you, Sergio! Zero reason to communicate!

SERGIO
My name's not Sergio. I'm here with pizza. It's... Fred.

PALOMA
Fred? Yeah, and I'm freakin' Ethel! I see you through the hole. Seriously, pretending to be Domino's? Nuh-uh. You are no Fred!

SERGIO
Yes, I am. I'm Fred, the local pizza guy.

PALOMA
Your mustache is lopsided. The "Dominos" on your hat is in craft glue. And I don't eat pizza-- I'm keto! *(Pause.)* Is this an emergency?

*(Pause.)*

SERGIO

...Yes.

*(PALOMA heaves, swings the door open as SERGIO ENTERS.)*

SERGIO

Of the heart.

*(She slams the door on him again.)*

SERGIO

Ugh, Paloma! For real! It's important! Please let me in. You're the love of my life. You're my everything. I'm only in town for this one last hour. Then I leave forever. And I feel like it's all over now...

PALOMA

'Cause it is!

SERGIO

I might as well just stop trying...

PALOMA

Please do!

SERGIO

Just quit it all!

PALOMA

Hey, whoa. What now?

*(She opens door, steps back. It just got real.)*

SERGIO

*(As he enters)* Naw, oh no, not like that. I won't do anything like that. *(Speaking very gently)* I brought some of your very personal items I know you could not live without. *(Taking items out of a bag)* Here-- jewelry, salt lamp, your cat mug.

PALOMA

Won't you come in.

*(SERGIO smiles, gestures for a hug or kiss. Paloma presents hand for a handshake. He tries to kiss it, she pulls away.)*

I said emergencies only so this best be urgent. Speak.

SERGIO

Yea, absolutely. It is. As I was saying...

*(He goes to sit.)*

PALOMA

I didn't say get comfortable.

SERGIO

Oh, sorry, yes, my dove.

PALOMA

Dove???!!

SERGIO

Apologies!! Old habits. Ugh, my sweet doe eyed--

PALOMA

Agggghh!!!

SERGIO

I mean, Paloma! Seriously didn't mean to. Imma get right to it. The emergency is... Kristoff... is dead.

PALOMA

Oh God. As in, a passing? A transition to the other side? I'm... beside myself. I've been barbaric. That is awful. I'm sorry I've been a villain. Here...

*(PALOMA extends her arms for a hug. They stand and hug for a moment. SERGIO fake cries, whimpers. While hugging...)*

Hey. Everything's gonna be alright. Oh, I'm so sorry. *(A beat)* Remind me, who exactly was Kristoff again?

SERGIO

My succulent.

PALOMA

Ughh!! Seriously?! A plant!

*(She shoves him off of her. Sergio goes flying back to the couch.)*

SERGIO

Dang, girl!! You're strong! You been boxing again?

PALOMA

You came here because a plant died?!

SERGIO

Well, hey listen! It's more than that! Kristoff was an important plant, like family! Haven't you heard that saying?

PALOMA

That's pets. "Pets are like family."

SERGIO

Kristoff came into my life the day we met. I thought you'd understand 'cause... you connect deeply to the earth! You fed our plants Fiji water while we drank tap. You sang to them. I was hoping for maybe some sympathy, empathy, any of the thees!

PALOMA

Well, I'm sorry for your loss. But you can bury Kristoff out where I buried the number of craps I give.

*(She shoos him to the door. He swoops around her, fakes a cough.)*

SERGIO

Wait. Cough-- attack! Oh-- I'm choking! Choking! I need-- water!!

*(He leaps over to the refrigerator, opens it, takes out a water filter, pours directly into mouth.)*

SERGIO

Uh oh, someone's drinkin' Kiwi Strawberry Snapple. I know someone only drinks KSS when they feel down...

*(He walks to her sweetly.)*

Do you miss me even the teensiest bit?

*(PALOMA jumps to SERGIO, knocks him over. They roll over once on the floor, struggling.)*

SERGIO

Whoa, you HAVE been training!

*(She pulls him up and twists his arm into a locked position. He squeals.)*

Ahhh... uncle! Mercy!! You win! You're stronger than me! Please let go! *(She lets go.)* Wheww!! Babe... I mean... understood. Time to go. Thank you for the moment of mourning, well, "observation." And the water. *(Beat.)* Oh! I noticed you took down the picture of us on your fridge... no problem. I always carry a spare wallet size with me so I'll just leave this one here on the counter for--

PALOMA

Sergio.

SERGIO

Yea.

PALOMA

Serge.

SERGIO

Yes.

PALOMA

Why are you really here?

*(He looks at the ceiling. He takes one step closer. He cocks his head. Another beat of silence... then falls to his knees, bawling.)*

SERGIO

I MISS YOU!!!! COME BACK TO ME, BABY DOVE!!! Please, my life is meaningless without you!!!!!

*(He wraps around her legs.)*

PALOMA

I'm sorry. It wasn't just the one big thing. It was thing after thing after thing.

SERGIO
That's the thing! Things are just things! We can go back in time and redo the whole thing!

PALOMA
Like when I surprised you with a charcuterie, you told me I chose all the wrong cheeses and it was inconsumable!

SERGIO
Naw!! I just meant... traditional charcuteries usually have some mozzarella...

PALOMA
You're the charcuterie master?

SERGIO
I was a cheesemonger...

PALOMA
So you know everything there is to know? You've met the creator of the first charcuterie?!

*(She gets right in his face. A pause. For a moment, her frown melts into a small smile. Faces inches from one another.)*

SERGIO
Yeah, that was Strabo, first century, Romans.

PALOMA
The word is French.

*(They kiss, close-mouthed, tight-lipped. An angry kiss. Paloma wipes her mouth and pushes him off.)*

Ughhhh!

SERGIO
Did that mean--

PALOMA
No!

SERGIO
Are you sure 'cause--

PALOMA
Certain. Okay, we've had a memorable goodbye. Could you please?

SERGIO
Yes. By all means. I know our time has truly come to a close. My parting words are-- hold up. Is this... the playlist I think it is?

PALOMA
It's on shuffle. If you like the song, that's coincidence.

SERGIO
No!!! It's a sign!! Our wedding playlist!! Phil Collins! You WERE thinking of us-- we were gonna play this at the wedding!

PALOMA
Sure, before you decided to cancel days before! Trust me, not on purpose.

SERGIO
Paloma! Remember, we danced to this, just us? *(He extends his hand for a dance. She slowly advances, wincing.)* On Terrell's patio with the big Christmas lights that one July? And you made a whole playlist the next day.

*(A moment between them as they slow dance.*
*Time slows down.)*

PALOMA
Ahh, yes. You're referring to the playlist I spent six hours curating. Yes. *(Beat.)* Now six hours of my life that I will never get back. Because someone... decided weddings were too trendy and mainstream and wanted to cancel days before?!! *(Breaking out of the dance.)* Now I don't know if I EVER wanna get married! I'm questioning all of existence! The only one who can give me the peace I need is my ferret, NUZZLES!

SERGIO
Paloma. I apologized. I know I was a monster. I just looked around at everyone getting a divorce. On top of climate change and capitalism and world hunger and disease and I-- I admit it, I snapped! I freaked out! But don't you remember-- this was our song?

PALOMA
Mmm, yes, I do remember. I said, "Phil Collins is my favorite too." Well, guess what... IT'S OVERPLAYED!!!

*(BAM! She stomps on his foot. He grabs it in pain.*
*PALOMA smiles to herself, takes a sip of a drink.*
*SERGIO hops.)*

SERGIO

Alright! Understood. I see that our door is closed and you've swallowed the key. You've tied up the brown paper packages with string.

PALOMA

What do I have to do in order for you to scurry away, peacefully?

SERGIO

Wow. Whew... well may I make a kind request for one final hug goodbye?

*(A pause. He looks teary-eyed, bats his eyelashes, opens arms. They start at one side of the room and over the next monologue, Paloma gradually backs him to the other side, by the door.)*

PALOMA

You have my enthusiastic consent... to pay me $20,000 for the other half of the wedding! Plus the cost of the private honeymoon boat I had to cancel, without refund! While you're at it, send me my rustic napkin holder, the extendable mango wood coffee table, and my matcha tea set! You can buy a new damn plant. This is NOT an emergency!!!

*(He is cowered into a corner, the shape of his body is tiny. He squeaks out...)*

SERGIO

Can we be friends?

PALOMA

AHHHHH!!!

*(Paloma picks him up, they grapple, slap their hands rapidly and awkwardly, have a back and forth. She then lifts him up off the ground, tosses him over her shoulder into a fireman's carry. She carries him out the door, takes him off, goes back in, and slams the door in a huff. She collapses to the floor. A beat. Sergio sneaks around the exterior of the entire building to a window. A few beats. Then through the open window...)*

SERGIO

Owwww, ow, ouch!! Paloma, darling... I mean... girl. For real-- uhh, I definitely just broke my ankle! *(Knocking)* Swear to God. Please, this is not a joke, not kidding! Paloma, pleaaaseee!! It's an emergency!!

***End of Play***